



DSAT FOUNDATION PROGRAM

Standard English Conventions

All 17 grammar and punctuation topics · theory with examples · 46 worked questions with Tip, Trap and Process of Elimination

CLC Educational Institute · Admissions Consulting & Test Preparation · Athens, since 1996



How to use this deck

Every topic includes

- An opening slide with the big idea
- Theory: rules, examples and reasons
- Spot-the-error practice pairs
- Worked examples with full solutions

How to study

- Read each rule AND its 'Why'
- Try the question BEFORE the solution slide
- Compare your thinking with the Process
- Review the Tip and the Trap

Every solution shows

- Process: the step-by-step thinking
- Tip: a shortcut to remember
- Trap: the mistake to avoid
- Process of Elimination: every choice explained

ΠΩΣ ΝΑ ΧΡΗΣΙΜΟΠΟΙΗΣΕΤΕ ΑΥΤΗ ΤΗΝ ΠΑΡΟΥΣΙΑΣΗ

Αυτή η παρουσίαση καλύπτει και τα 17 θέματα γραμματικής και στίξης. Κάθε ενότητα εξηγεί όχι μόνο τον κανόνα, αλλά και ΓΙΑΤΙ ισχύει. Μελετήστε τα λυμένα παραδείγματα βήμα-βήμα πριν δείτε την απάντηση.



Same question, every time

THE QUESTION

“Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?”

1

All four choices usually mean the same thing

What changes is the GRAMMAR or PUNCTUATION

2

Look at HOW the choices differ

That difference names the rule being tested

3

Choose by RULE

Never by how a sentence ‘sounds’

Your 17 topics at a glance



PUNCTUATION

- 1 The Comma
- 2 The Semicolon
- 3 The Colon
- 4 The Dash
- 5 The Period

SENTENCE BOUNDARIES

- 6 Independent vs. Dependent Clauses
- 7 Run-ons & Comma Splices
- 8 Fragments
- 9 Logical Separation of Ideas

WORD FORMS & AGREEMENT

- 10 Parts of Speech
- 11 Verbs & Tenses
- 12 Subject-Verb Agreement
- 13 Pronouns
- 14 Nouns & Apostrophes
- 15 Adjectives & Adverbs

MODIFIERS & STRUCTURE

- 16 Modifiers
- 17 Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

1

The Comma

One idea behind every comma rule: separate, don't split.

Το Κόμμα

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A comma separates a piece of information from the rest of the sentence — either because that information is EXTRA, or because the sentence structure needs a small pause.

EXAMPLE

After the storm, the streets flooded.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Το Κόμμα

Ένα σημείο στίξης που δείχνει μια σύντομη παύση ή διαχωρίζει μέρη μιας πρότασης.

WHY IT MATTERS

- The most common punctuation mark on the Digital SAT
- Most errors are commas that should NOT be there
- Four ‘use’ rules and four ‘don’t use’ rules cover almost every question

1

Four places a comma belongs

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

After an introductory phrase or clause

After the storm, the streets flooded.

The comma marks where the introduction ends and the main sentence starts.

Before FANBOYS joining two full sentences

She studied hard, so she passed.

The comma goes BEFORE the FANBOYS word, never after it.

Around non-essential (extra) information

My brother, who lives in Spain, is visiting.

Remove the phrase: the sentence still works, so it is extra.

Between items in a list of three or more

She bought apples, oranges, and bananas.

Commas show where each item ends and the next begins.

FANBOYS: the seven joining words

F

for

A

and

N

nor

B

but

O

or

Y

yet

S

so

The rule

- Two full sentences + FANBOYS
- Comma BEFORE the FANBOYS word
- She studied hard, so she passed.

No comma

- One subject, two verbs
- No second subject after the word
- She ran and won.

Watch out

- Comma goes before, never after
- However and therefore are NOT FANBOYS
- A comma alone cannot join two sentences

1

Four places a comma does not belong

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
Between a subject and its verb	✗ <i>The main reason, is pollution.</i>	Subject and verb belong together — no pause.
Around an essential “that” clause	✗ <i>The book, that I borrowed, was great.</i>	“That I borrowed” tells WHICH book — it is essential.
Between two verbs that share one subject	✗ <i>She ran, and won.</i>	There is no second subject, so “and” is not joining two sentences.
Between adjectives that cannot swap or take “and”	✗ <i>A large, wooden table.</i>	“Wooden large table” sounds wrong, so no comma.

1

Spot the comma error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The alarm went off, no one moved.

✗ Walking home Sam saw a fox.

✗ My car, which is ten years old still runs well.

✗ The reason for the delay, was the weather.

RIGHT

✓ The alarm went off, but no one moved.

✓ Walking home, Sam saw a fox.

✓ My car, which is ten years old, still runs well.

✓ The reason for the delay was the weather.

WHY

Comma splice: a comma alone cannot join two sentences.

An introductory phrase needs a comma after it.

Extra information needs a comma on BOTH sides.

Never split a subject from its verb.

Three quick tests



Test 1 — Extra or essential?

- Cross the phrase out
- Sentence still works → extra → commas on BOTH sides
- Meaning changes → essential → no commas

Test 2 — Two sentences?

- Find a subject + verb on each side
- Yes → comma + FANBOYS (or ; or .)
- A comma alone = comma splice

Watch out

- “That” = essential = no commas
- “Which” = usually extra = commas
- Never one comma around extra information

Worked Example 1.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The museum, which opened in 1990, houses a large collection of modern art.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B remove both commas
- C remove only the first comma
- D remove only the second comma

1

Worked Example 1.1: Solution

Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. Find the phrase between the commas: “which opened in 1990”.
2. Cross it out: “The museum houses a large collection of modern art.” still works.
3. So the phrase is extra (non-essential) information.
4. Extra information needs commas on BOTH sides — both are already there.

TIP

- Cross-out test: if the sentence survives, the phrase is extra and takes a PAIR of commas.
- “Which” + commas usually travel together.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ **A pair of commas around extra information.**
- B** ✗ No commas would treat extra detail as essential.
- C** ✗ One comma left: the phrase opens but never closes.
- D** ✗ One comma left: the phrase is closed but never opened.

TRAP

- Removing commas because “too many commas look wrong”.
- Choosing a change just because it is offered — “correct as written” can be right.

Worked Example 1.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Maria finished her homework, and then went to soccer practice.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B remove the comma
- C add a comma after “then”
- D add a comma after “Maria”

1

Worked Example 1.2: Solution

Answer: B — remove the comma

PROCESS

1. Find the subjects: only one — “Maria”.
2. Find the verbs: “finished” and “went” — two verbs, one subject.
3. “And” joins two verbs, not two full sentences.
4. A comma before “and” is only for joining two full sentences — remove it.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The comma splits one subject from its second verb.
- B** ✓ **No comma: “and” simply links two verbs.**
- C** ✗ A comma after “then” interrupts the verb phrase for no reason.
- D** ✗ A comma after “Maria” separates subject from verb.

TIP

- Look AFTER “and”: no new subject means no comma.
- Compare: “She ran and won.”

TRAP

- Adding commas because “and then” feels like a pause.
- Treating the sentence as two sentences when the second half has no subject.

2

The Semicolon

A stronger comma, a softer period.

Η Άνω Τελεία (Semicolon)

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A semicolon joins two complete sentences (independent clauses) that are closely related in meaning, without a connecting word like “and” or “but”.

EXAMPLE

The library was quiet; everyone was studying for finals.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Η Ανω Τελεία (Semicolon)

Ένα σημείο στίξης που ενώνει δύο πλήρεις προτάσεις που σχετίζονται στενά.

WHY IT MATTERS

- One main job: join two independent clauses
- BOTH sides must be able to stand alone
- Also separates long list items that already contain commas

Three jobs of a semicolon



RULE	EXAMPLE	WHY
Join two full, related sentences	<i>The library was quiet; everyone was studying for finals.</i>	Both halves are complete, and they describe the same scene.
Come before a transition word like “however” or “therefore”	<i>The results were promising; however, more testing is needed.</i>	Semicolon BEFORE the transition, comma AFTER it.
Separate list items that contain commas	<i>We visited Athens, Greece; Rome, Italy; and Paris, France.</i>	Semicolons show where each city-and-country pair ends.

Words that take a semicolon before them

CONTRAST

however • nevertheless • nonetheless • instead •
otherwise • conversely • in contrast

RESULT

therefore • thus • consequently • hence •
accordingly • as a result

ADDITION

moreover • furthermore • additionally • in addition •
besides • likewise • similarly

EXAMPLE, EMPHASIS & TIME

for example • for instance • in fact • indeed •
meanwhile • subsequently

THE PATTERN Full sentence ; transition , full sentence

The test was long; however, most students finished.

Three places a semicolon does not belong

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
To join a sentence and a fragment	✗ <i>She had visited Rome; and Florence.</i>	“And Florence” cannot stand alone.
Before a FANBOYS word	✗ <i>It was raining; but we went out anyway.</i>	FANBOYS take a comma, not a semicolon.
To introduce a list after a complete sentence	✗ <i>We bought three things; milk, eggs, and bread.</i>	A colon introduces a list.

2

Spot the semicolon error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The results were promising, however, more testing is needed.

✗ She is tired; but she keeps going.

✗ The store closed early; because the staff were tired.

✗ Rome, Italy, Paris, France, and Athens, Greece.

RIGHT

→
✓ The results were promising; however, more testing is needed.

→
✓ She is tired, but she keeps going.

→
✓ The store closed early because the staff were tired.

→
✓ Rome, Italy; Paris, France; and Athens, Greece.

WHY

“However” joining two sentences needs a semicolon before it.

Never combine a semicolon with FANBOYS.

A semicolon cannot join a dependent clause.

Commas inside items need semicolons between items.

The semicolon in three lines

The test

- Cover each side
- Could each stand alone?
- Yes on BOTH sides → semicolon works

The pattern

- Full sentence ; however, full sentence
- Same pattern for therefore, moreover, instead
- Semicolon before, comma after

Watch out

- No capital after a semicolon (unless a name or “I”)
- Semicolon ≠ comma + FANBOYS: pick one
- A fragment on either side = wrong

Worked Example 2.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

Located in the northern United States, the Great Lakes Basin contains roughly 35,000 islands. Lake Superior has Grand Island, for example. Lake Michigan has Belle Isle. Lake Huron, though, is home _____ the largest island of them all: Manitoulin Island.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A to;

B to—

C to

D to,

Worked Example 2.1: Solution

Answer: C — to

PROCESS

1. Look at the word before the blank: “home to” — “to” is a preposition.
2. A preposition must connect straight to its object: “the largest island of them all”.
3. Nothing may come between a preposition and its object.
4. Choose the option with NO punctuation.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A semicolon needs a complete sentence before it; “...is home to” is not one.
- B** ✗ A dash would cut the preposition off from its object.
- C** ✓ **No punctuation: “home to the largest island”.**
- D** ✗ A comma separates the preposition from its object.

TIP

- When a blank sits inside a phrase, the choice with no punctuation is often right.
- Before choosing ; or — ask: is everything BEFORE the mark a complete sentence?

TRAP

- The colon later in the sentence tempts you to add more punctuation.
- A semicolon or dash “sounds” dramatic — but it splits “to” from its object.

Worked Example 2.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The recipe called for two cups of flour, however, we only had one.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change the first comma to a semicolon
- C remove both commas
- D change the second comma to a semicolon

Worked Example 2.2: Solution

Answer: B — change the first comma to a semicolon

PROCESS

1. Check the left side: “The recipe called for two cups of flour” — complete.
2. Check the right side: “we only had one” — also complete.
3. “However” is a transition joining two full sentences.
4. Pattern: full sentence ; however, full sentence — so the first comma becomes a semicolon.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Comma splice: a comma cannot join two full sentences.
- B** ✓ Semicolon before “however”, comma after.
- C** ✗ Removing both commas creates a run-on.
- D** ✗ The splice stays, and “however” is cut off from its clause.

TIP

- “However” can never repair a comma splice by itself.
- Memorize the pattern: ; however,

TRAP

- Believing commas on both sides of “however” are always right.
- Choosing D: it changes the wrong comma and leaves the splice.

3

The Colon

Everything BEFORE a colon must be a complete sentence.

Η Ανω και Κάτω Τελεία (Colon)

THEORY
5 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A colon introduces something — a list, an explanation, an example or a quotation. The rule that trips up most students: the words **BEFORE** the colon must be a complete sentence on their own.

EXAMPLE

The chef prepared three dishes: soup, salad, and dessert.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Η Ανω και Κάτω Τελεία (Colon)

Ένα σημείο στίξης που εισάγει μια εξήγηση, λίστα, ή παράδειγμα μετά από μια πλήρη πρόταση.

WHY IT MATTERS

- After the colon: a list, a word, a phrase, or a sentence
- Before the colon: ALWAYS a complete sentence
- Never right after a verb or a preposition

Three jobs of a colon

RULE	EXAMPLE	WHY
Introduce a list after a complete sentence	<i>The chef prepared three dishes: soup, salad, and dessert.</i>	“The chef prepared three dishes” is already a full sentence.
Introduce an explanation	<i>She had one goal: to win the championship.</i>	What follows explains the “one goal”.
Introduce a quotation after a complete sentence	<i>The coach had a simple rule: “Practice like you play.”</i>	The quotation reveals what the rule was.

Three places a colon does not belong

RULE

WRONG EXAMPLE

WHY

After an incomplete sentence

✗ *The ingredients are: flour, sugar, and eggs.*

“The ingredients are” is not complete without the list.

Directly after a verb or preposition

✗ *She enjoys: hiking and swimming.*

A colon cannot interrupt a verb and its object.

After “such as” or “including”

✗ *Fruits such as: apples and pears.*

These words already introduce the list.

Spot the colon error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The ingredients are: flour, sugar, and eggs.

✗ She enjoys: hiking and swimming.

✗ Her goal was clear; to win the title.

✗ Fruits such as: apples and pears.

RIGHT



✓ The recipe needs three ingredients: flour, sugar, and eggs.



✓ She enjoys hiking and swimming.



✓ Her goal was clear: to win the title.



✓ Fruits such as apples and pears.

WHY

Make the part before the colon a complete sentence.

No colon between a verb and its objects.

“to win the title” is not a sentence, so a semicolon fails.

“Such as” already introduces the list.

The colon in three lines



The test

- Cover everything after the colon
- A complete sentence left?
→ colon is fine
- Not complete → remove the colon

What can follow

- A list
- A single word: “one fear: heights”
- A phrase, a sentence, or a quotation

Watch out

- A colon after is / are / was is usually wrong
- A colon promises an explanation — deliver one
- Unlike a semicolon, the part AFTER may be short

Worked Example 3.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

After the printing press was introduced in 1440, handwritten manuscripts from Europe's medieval period were often destroyed and the paper used for other purposes. In one instance, pages _____ a collection of Norse tales dating to 1270 were discovered lining a bishop's miter (hat).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A from:

B from,

C from

D from—

Worked Example 3.1: Solution



Answer: C — from

PROCESS

1. Read the words before the blank: “In one instance, pages from” — not a complete sentence.
2. “From a collection of Norse tales...” says WHERE the pages came from: essential information.
3. The main verb “were discovered” comes after the phrase.
4. No punctuation belongs inside this phrase.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A colon after an incomplete sentence.
- B** ✗ A comma splits “from” from its object.
- C** ✓ **No punctuation: the phrase flows straight into the noun.**
- D** ✗ A dash after an incomplete sentence cuts the phrase in two.

TIP

- A colon or dash needs a complete sentence BEFORE it — test that first.
- Subject → modifier → verb: no mark is needed until the phrase ends.

TRAP

- A colon or dash looks sophisticated after “pages from”.
- A comma looks like a natural pause after a long subject.

Worked Example 3.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The three ingredients for the soup are: carrots, onions, and celery.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B remove the colon
- C replace the colon with a semicolon
- D replace the colon with a dash

Worked Example 3.2: Solution



Answer: B — remove the colon

PROCESS

1. Cover everything after the colon.
2. What remains: “The three ingredients for the soup are” — incomplete.
3. A colon needs a complete sentence before it.
4. Remove the colon: “...are carrots, onions, and celery.”

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The colon follows “are”; the first part is not a sentence.
- B** ✓ **No colon: the list completes the verb.**
- C** ✗ A semicolon also needs a complete sentence before it.
- D** ✗ A dash after “are” has the same problem as the colon.

TIP

- Colon test: cover the end — is a full sentence left?
- A colon right after “is / are / was” is almost always wrong.

TRAP

- Believing every list needs a colon.
- Swapping in a semicolon or dash — they also need a full sentence before them.

4

The Dash

Flexible — but only when used consistently.

Η Παύλα (Dash)

THEORY
5 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

The dash (—) is the most flexible mark on the test: it can do the job of a comma, a colon, or parentheses. The exam checks that you recognise which job it is doing — and that you use it consistently.

EXAMPLE

My brother — who lives in Spain — is visiting.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Η Παύλα (Dash)

Ένα σημείο στίξης που τονίζει ή απομονώνει πρόσθετες πληροφορίες, πιο έντονα από το κόμμα.

WHY IT MATTERS

- A PAIR of dashes works like a pair of commas
- A SINGLE dash works like a colon
- Never mix a dash with a comma around the same phrase

Three jobs of a dash

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

A pair of dashes around extra information

My brother — who lives in Spain — is visiting.

Works like commas; open with a dash, close with a dash.

A single dash to introduce an explanation

She had one goal — to win the championship.

Does a colon's job with a more emphatic tone.

A dash to show an abrupt change

I was going to call you — actually, let's meet.

Shows a sudden shift in thought.

Two places a dash does not belong

RULE

WRONG EXAMPLE

WHY

Mixing a dash with a comma around one phrase

✗ *My brother — who lives in Spain, is visiting.*

A phrase opened with a dash must be closed with a dash.

After a simple introductory phrase

✗ *Walking to school — I saw my friend.*

A comma is the correct mark here.

4

Spot the dash error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The results — though surprising, were accurate.

✗ My brother, who lives in Spain — is visiting.

✗ Walking to school — I saw my friend.

✗ The experiment — despite months of work, — failed.

RIGHT

✓ The results — though surprising — were accurate.

✓ My brother — who lives in Spain — is visiting.

✓ Walking to school, I saw my friend.

✓ The experiment — despite months of work — failed.

WHY

Match the pair: dash ... dash.

Never open with a comma and close with a dash.

An introductory phrase takes a comma.

Remove the extra comma: a dash pair needs no comma.

The dash in three lines



Pair rule

- Open with a dash → close with a dash
- Open with a comma → close with a comma
- Never mix

Single dash

- Acts like a colon
- The words BEFORE it should be a complete sentence
- One dash or one colon — rarely both offered

Consistency check

- Look at the OTHER end of the phrase
- Already a dash there? You need a dash
- Already a comma? You need a comma

Worked Example 4.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The experiment — despite months of preparation, — failed to produce useful results.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B remove the comma after “preparation”
- C remove both dashes
- D replace the first dash with a comma

Worked Example 4.1: Solution

Answer: B — remove the comma after “preparation”

PROCESS

1. Spot the extra phrase: “despite months of preparation”.
2. It opens with a dash, so it must close with a dash.
3. A comma + dash after “preparation” is a double mark.
4. Remove the comma: “...preparation — failed...”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A dash cannot be closed with a comma-dash combination.
- B** ✓ **Dash ... dash: a matched pair.**
- C** ✗ Without any marks, the extra phrase is not set off.
- D** ✗ A comma + leftover dash still mismatches.

TIP

- Pair rule: dash...dash or comma...comma, never mixed.
- Check BOTH ends of the extra phrase.

TRAP

- Removing both dashes just because they look heavy.
- Changing one mark but leaving the other mismatched.

Worked Example 4.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The new policy has one clear purpose: to reduce paperwork for small businesses.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B replace the colon with a semicolon
- C replace the colon with a period
- D replace the colon with a comma and the word “and”

Worked Example 4.2: Solution



Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. Cover what follows the colon: “The new policy has one clear purpose” — complete.
2. After the colon: “to reduce paperwork...” explains the purpose.
3. Complete sentence + colon + explanation is correct.
4. No change needed.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ **Complete sentence, then a colon, then the explanation.**
- B** ✗ “to reduce paperwork...” cannot stand alone, so a semicolon fails.
- C** ✗ A period leaves a fragment: “To reduce paperwork...”.
- D** ✗ “and to reduce...” breaks the structure and the meaning.

TIP

- “One purpose / one goal / one problem” is a classic colon set-up.
- A colon and a single dash do the same job — you will not see both as correct.

TRAP

- Changing a correct sentence because other choices look familiar.
- Using a semicolon: it needs a complete sentence on BOTH sides.

5

The Period

The simplest mark — tested as one way to separate two ideas.

Η Τελεία (Period)

THEORY
5 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A period ends a complete sentence. On the Digital SAT it is one of several ways to separate two ideas — and the question it asks is the same as the semicolon's: are BOTH sides complete sentences?

EXAMPLE

The rain stopped. The sun came out.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Η Τελεία (Period)

Ένα σημείο στίξης που τερματίζει μια πλήρη πρόταση.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Two complete sentences → a period is always grammatical
- A period after a fragment is always an error
- A period is never wrong between two full sentences — only sometimes less elegant

Two jobs of a period

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

End one complete sentence before starting another

The rain stopped. The sun came out.

Both halves are independent sentences.

Replace a comma splice

The team practiced daily. Their effort paid off.

A period is always a safe, correct fix.

Three places a period does not belong

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
After a fragment	✗ <i>Because she was tired. She went to bed early.</i>	“Because she was tired” is a dependent clause.
Before a non-essential “which” clause	✗ <i>She wrote three books. Which all became bestsellers.</i>	“Which” starts extra information that needs a comma.
Between an explained idea and its explanation	✗ <i>He had one goal. To win.</i>	“To win” is not a sentence; use a colon.

Spot the period error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ Because she was tired. She went to bed early.

✗ She wrote three books. Which all became bestsellers.

✗ The lights went out. Leaving us in the dark.

✗ He had one goal. To win.

RIGHT

✓ Because she was tired, she went to bed early.

✓ She wrote three books, which all became bestsellers.

✓ The lights went out, leaving us in the dark.

✓ He had one goal: to win.

WHY

Attach the dependent clause to the main clause.

“Which” clauses attach with a comma.

“Leaving us in the dark” has no subject of its own.

A colon connects an idea to its explanation.

The period in three lines



The test

- Read the words BEFORE the period alone
- Complete? Fine
- Incomplete? It's a fragment

Same as the semicolon

- Two full sentences → period OR semicolon
- Both can be grammatical
- Context decides the best style

Watch out

- A capital letter ≠ a sentence
- Starting with because / although / while? Check for the main clause
- “Which” and “-ing” pieces belong to the previous sentence

Worked Example 5.1

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Although the museum was closed for renovations. Visitors could still tour the gardens.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** change the period to a comma
- C** change “Although” to “Because”
- D** change the period to a semicolon

Worked Example 5.1: Solution



Answer: B — change the period to a comma

PROCESS

1. Read the words before the period on their own.
2. “Although the museum was closed for renovations” starts with “although”: dependent.
3. A period can only end a complete sentence.
4. Replace it with a comma to attach the clause to the main sentence.

TIP

- Subordinating word at the start (although, because, while)? Look for the comma.
- Dependent clause first → comma → independent clause.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The period leaves a fragment.
- B** ✓ **The comma attaches the dependent clause to the main clause.**
- C** ✗ “Because” still opens a dependent clause — the fragment remains.
- D** ✗ A semicolon needs a complete sentence before it.

TRAP

- Trusting a capital letter and a period as proof of a sentence.
- Choosing the semicolon: it needs two independent clauses.

Worked Example 5.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The bakery opens at six every morning. Fresh bread is ready by seven.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** combine the sentences with only a comma
- C** remove the period and the capital letter on “Fresh”
- D** add “and” before the period

Worked Example 5.2: Solution



Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. Left side: “The bakery opens at six every morning” — complete.
2. Right side: “Fresh bread is ready by seven” — complete.
3. Two complete sentences are properly separated by a period.
4. Leave it alone.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ **A period between two independent clauses.**
- B** ✗ A comma alone creates a comma splice.
- C** ✗ Removing the period creates a run-on.
- D** ✗ “and” before the period is ungrammatical.

TIP

- Two full sentences? A period is always safe.
- “Correct as written” is a real answer — don’t fix what isn’t broken.

TRAP

- Feeling the two ideas “belong together” and joining them with a comma.
- Over-editing a sentence that is already correct.

6

Independent vs. Dependent Clauses

The one skill behind nearly every punctuation question.

Ανεξάρτητες και Εξαρτημένες Προτάσεις

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

An INDEPENDENT clause is a complete sentence that can stand alone. A DEPENDENT clause is an incomplete thought that needs another clause to make sense. Before you choose any punctuation, decide which type sits on each side.

EXAMPLE

The dog barked.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Ανεξάρτητες και Εξαρτημένες Προτάσεις

Μια ανεξάρτητη πρόταση μπορεί να σταθεί μόνη της.
Μια εξαρτημένη πρόταση όχι.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Commas, semicolons, colons and periods all depend on clause type
- Dependent clauses start with a subordinating word
- A dependent clause has a subject and a verb — and is STILL incomplete

How to tell them apart

TYPE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Independent clause: subject + verb + complete thought

The dog barked.

It could stand alone as a full sentence.

Dependent clause: starts with a subordinating word

Because the dog barked...

“Because” leaves the reader waiting for the result.

Subordinating words: although, because, since, while, if, when, unless, after, before

Although she was tired...

Any clause opening with one of these cannot stand alone.

6

Two common clause mistakes

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
Ending a sentence after a dependent clause	✗ <i>Because she studied hard.</i>	It has a subject and verb, but “because” leaves it unfinished.
Joining a dependent clause with a semicolon	✗ <i>Although it rained; the game continued.</i>	A semicolon needs TWO independent clauses.

Match the clause pair to the punctuation

CLAUSE PAIR

CORRECT PATTERN

EXAMPLE

Independent + Independent

; or . or , + FANBOYS

It rained, so the game was postponed.

Dependent + Independent

Dependent , Independent

Although it rained, the game continued.

Independent + Dependent

Usually NO comma

The game continued although it rained.

Spot the clause error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ Although it rained the game continued.

✗ It rained, the game continued.

✗ Since the bridge was closed. Drivers took another route.

✗ Although it rained; the game continued.

RIGHT

→ ✓ Although it rained, the game continued.

→ ✓ It rained, so the game continued.

→ ✓ Since the bridge was closed, drivers took another route.

→ ✓ Although it rained, the game continued.

WHY

Dependent clause first needs a comma.

Two independent clauses need comma + FANBOYS.

A period cannot follow a dependent clause.

A semicolon needs two independent clauses.

Clause checks

The stand-alone test

- Read the clause by itself
- Does it sound finished?
- Or do you wait for more?

Subordinators to know

- because • although • since
- while • if • when
- unless • after • before

Watch out

- Subject + verb does NOT guarantee independence
- Long ≠ complete
- Check BOTH sides before choosing a mark

Worked Example 6.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

While the concert was still going on the band decided to add an extra song.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B add a comma after “on”
- C add a semicolon after “on”
- D add a period after “on”

Worked Example 6.1: Solution

Answer: B — add a comma after “on”

PROCESS

1. Left: “While the concert was still going on” — starts with “while”: dependent.
2. Right: “the band decided to add an extra song” — independent.
3. Dependent clause + independent clause → separate with a comma.
4. Add the comma after “on”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Missing comma between the two clauses.
- B** ✓ **A comma after the dependent clause.**
- C** ✗ A semicolon leaves a dependent clause alone on the left.
- D** ✗ A period creates a fragment.

TIP

- Opening subordinator + no comma = suspect a missing comma.
- Say it aloud: the natural pause marks the spot.

TRAP

- A semicolon or period feels “stronger” but leaves a fragment.
- Leaving it as written because it reads smoothly.

Worked Example 6.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The bridge was built in 1932, it is still used by thousands of drivers every day.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change the comma to a semicolon
- C change the comma to a colon
- D remove the comma with no replacement

6

Worked Example 6.2: Solution

Answer: B — change the comma to a semicolon

PROCESS

1. Left: “The bridge was built in 1932” — independent.
2. Right: “it is still used by thousands of drivers every day” — independent.
3. Two independent clauses joined by only a comma = comma splice.
4. A semicolon joins two related independent clauses.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Comma splice.
- B** ✓ **A semicolon joins the two independent clauses.**
- C** ✗ A colon promises an explanation; the second clause only adds a fact.
- D** ✗ No punctuation = run-on.

TIP

- Two subjects, two verbs, one weak comma → splice.
- Fixes: ; or . or , + FANBOYS.

TRAP

- A colon: the second clause adds a fact, it doesn't explain the first.
- Removing the comma only turns a splice into a run-on.

7

Run-ons & Comma Splices

Two full sentences, one weak connection.

Ενωμένες Προτάσεις (Run-ons & Comma Splices)

THEORY
7 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A RUN-ON joins two independent clauses with NO punctuation. A COMMA SPLICE joins them with ONLY a comma. Both have the same fix: separate the clauses properly.

WRONG EXAMPLE

The rain stopped everyone went outside.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Ενωμένες Προτάσεις (Run-ons & Comma Splices)

Δύο πλήρεις προτάσεις που ενώνονται λανθασμένα, χωρίς σωστό σημείο στίξης.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Among the most common errors on the Digital SAT
- Both errors involve TWO independent clauses
- Four reliable fixes — learn all four

Two errors, one cause

ERROR

EXAMPLE

WHY

Run-on: two full sentences, no punctuation

✗ *The rain stopped everyone went outside.*

Nothing separates two complete sentences.

Comma splice: two full sentences, only a comma

✗ *The rain stopped, everyone went outside.*

A comma alone is too weak to join two sentences.

FANBOYS: the joining words for fix 3

F

for

A

and

N

nor

B

but

O

or

Y

yet

S

so

The rule

- Two full sentences + FANBOYS
- Comma BEFORE the FANBOYS word
- She studied hard, so she passed.

No comma

- One subject, two verbs
- No second subject after the word
- She ran and won.

Watch out

- Comma goes before, never after
- However and therefore are NOT FANBOYS
- A comma alone cannot join two sentences

Four correct fixes

FIX

EXAMPLE

WHY

1 • Use a period

The rain stopped. Everyone went outside.

Two separate sentences — always safe.

2 • Use a semicolon

The rain stopped; everyone went outside.

Joins two closely related independent clauses.

3 • Use a comma + FANBOYS

The rain stopped, so everyone went outside.

The FANBOYS word does the joining.

4 • Make one clause dependent

Because the rain stopped, everyone went outside.

The only way a comma can sit between the two ideas.

Fake fixes that don't work

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
A comma + a transition word	✗ <i>The rain stopped, however, everyone went outside.</i>	“However” is not a FANBOYS word; the splice remains.
An extra comma after the FANBOYS word	✗ <i>The rain stopped, so, everyone went outside.</i>	The conjunction must connect directly to its clause.
FANBOYS with no comma between full sentences	✗ <i>The rain stopped so everyone went outside.</i>	The comma must come BEFORE the FANBOYS word.

Spot the error — and fix it



WRONG

✗ The lights went out the generator started.

✗ The lights went out, the generator started.

✗ Many students find chemistry difficult, the concepts are abstract.

✗ The test was hard, however, most students passed.

RIGHT

→
✓ The lights went out; the generator started.

→
✓ The lights went out, so the generator started.

→
✓ Many students find chemistry difficult.
The concepts are abstract.

→
✓ The test was hard; however, most students passed.

WHY

Run-on fixed with a semicolon.

Splice fixed with comma + FANBOYS.

Splice fixed with a period.

A transition word needs a semicolon before it.

Run-ons & splices in three lines



First check

- Underline a subject + verb on each side
- Both sides can stand alone?
- Then suspect a run-on or splice

The four fixes

- Period
- Semicolon
- Comma + FANBOYS • or •
a dependent clause

Watch out

- Comma BEFORE the FANBOYS word, not after
- Transition words are not FANBOYS
- Commas never join two full sentences alone

Worked Example 7.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

At 1,280 meters, the Golden Gate Bridge in the United States is one of the longest suspension bridges in the _____ the Tsing Ma Bridge in China, at 1,377 meters, is even longer.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A world but

B world, but,

C world,

D world, but

Worked Example 7.1: Solution

Answer: D — world, but

PROCESS

1. Left of the blank: “...one of the longest suspension bridges in the world” — complete.
2. Right of the blank: “the Tsing Ma Bridge... is even longer” — complete.
3. Two independent clauses need comma + FANBOYS (or ; or .).
4. “But” shows contrast (even longer): choose “world, but”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ No comma before “but”: run-on.
- B** ✗ The extra comma after “but” separates the conjunction from its clause.
- C** ✗ A comma alone: comma splice.
- D** ✓ **Comma + “but” joins the two independent clauses.**

TIP

- The comma goes BEFORE the FANBOYS word — never after it.
- Check that both sides are complete before choosing.

TRAP

- “world, but,” looks extra careful — the second comma splits “but” from its clause.
- Dropping the comma looks fine when you read fast.

Worked Example 7.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Many students find chemistry difficult, the abstract concepts can be hard to visualize.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change the comma to a period
- C remove the comma
- D add “however” after the comma

Worked Example 7.2: Solution

Answer: B — change the comma to a period

PROCESS

1. Left: “Many students find chemistry difficult” — complete.
2. Right: “the abstract concepts can be hard to visualize” — complete.
3. A lone comma between them is a comma splice.
4. A period separates them into two correct sentences.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Comma splice.
- B** ✓ **A period creates two proper sentences.**
- C** ✗ Run-on.
- D** ✗ A transition word after a comma still leaves a splice.

TIP

- “however”, “therefore”, “also” do NOT repair a splice after a comma.
- Only a period, a semicolon, or comma + FANBOYS can.

TRAP

- Adding a transition word and thinking that fixes it.
- Deleting the comma: the run-on remains.

8

Fragments

Looks like a sentence. Isn't one.

Ημιτελείς Προτάσεις (Fragments)

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A fragment is punctuated like a sentence — capital letter, period — but it is missing something essential: a subject, a main verb, or a complete thought. It is the opposite problem from a run-on.

WRONG EXAMPLE

The scientist, known for her groundbreaking research.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Ημιτελείς Προτάσεις (Fragments)

Μια ομάδα λέξεων που μοιάζει με πρόταση αλλά δεν εκφράζει μια πλήρη σκέψη.

WHY IT MATTERS

- A run-on crams too much together; a fragment breaks off too little
- Fragments often start with -ing words, because, although, before
- The fix is almost always to ATTACH the fragment

What can be missing

KIND

EXAMPLE

WHY

Missing a main verb

✗ *The scientist, known for her groundbreaking research.*

It has a subject but never says what she DID.

A dependent clause standing alone

✗ *Because the weather was bad.*

“Because” leaves the thought unfinished.

A phrase mistaken for a sentence

✗ *Running through the park every morning.*

No subject performs a complete action.

Short does NOT mean fragment

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

A command is a complete sentence

Close the door.

The subject “you” is understood.

Two words can be a full sentence

Birds sing.

It has a subject and a verb.

Long does NOT mean complete

✗ *Hoping to finish the long report before the deadline on Friday.*

No subject, no main verb — however many words.



Three ways to repair a fragment

FIX	EXAMPLE	WHY
Attach it to the sentence BEFORE it	<i>The committee reviewed the proposals before selecting a winner.</i>	Fragment after a sentence → join them (often with no comma).
Attach it to the sentence AFTER it	<i>Exhausted after the flight, the travelers went to their hotel.</i>	Fragment before a sentence → join them with a comma.
Add the missing subject or verb	<i>The scientist, known for her research, won the prize.</i>	Give the fragment its own main verb.

Spot the fragment — and fix it

WRONG

✗ Running late for the bus. She skipped breakfast.

✗ The dog barked. Barking loudly at the mail carrier.

✗ Although the team trained hard. They lost the match.

✗ The museum, famous for its sculptures.

RIGHT

➔ ✓ Running late for the bus, she skipped breakfast.

➔ ✓ The dog barked, barking loudly at the mail carrier.

➔ ✓ Although the team trained hard, they lost the match.

➔ ✓ The museum, famous for its sculptures, attracts millions.

WHY

The phrase describes “she” — attach it.

Attach the -ing phrase to the sentence before it.

Dependent clause + main clause.

Add the missing main verb.

Fragments in three lines



The test

- Read the group of words alone
- Does it need something else to make sense?
- Subject + verb + complete thought, or it's a fragment

Warning signs

- Starts with an -ing word
- Starts with because, although, while, before
- Starts with "which"

Watch out

- Don't trust a capital letter and a period
- Subject + verb can still be a fragment ("Because it rained.")
- Fix by attaching, not by adding punctuation alone

Worked Example 8.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The committee reviewed dozens of proposals.
Before finally selecting a winner.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B remove the period and make “Before” lowercase
- C change the period to a semicolon
- D change the period to a comma and keep “Before” capitalized

Worked Example 8.1: Solution



Answer: B — remove the period and make “Before” lowercase

PROCESS

1. Test the second part alone: “Before finally selecting a winner”.
2. No subject and no main verb — it is a fragment.
3. Attach it to the sentence it belongs to.
4. Result: “...proposals before finally selecting a winner.”

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Leaves the fragment.
- B** ✓ **Attaches the fragment to the main clause.**
- C** ✗ A semicolon cannot join a clause to a fragment.
- D** ✗ A capital after a comma is an error and still looks like a new sentence.

TIP

- Short piece starting with before / after / because / while? Look for a subject + verb.
- Fix a fragment by attaching it, not by decorating it.

TRAP

- A semicolon feels like a connector, but needs a complete clause after it.
- Keeping the capital letter leaves the fragment in place.

Worked Example 8.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Exhausted after the long flight. The travelers went straight to their hotel.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** change the period after “flight” to a comma
- C** change the period after “flight” to a semicolon
- D** remove the word “Exhausted”

Worked Example 8.2: Solution



Answer: B — change the period after “flight” to a comma

PROCESS

1. Test the first part alone: “Exhausted after the long flight”.
2. No subject and no main verb — fragment.
3. It describes the travelers, so it belongs in their sentence.
4. Replace the period with a comma: “...flight, the travelers went...”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The fragment stays.
- B** ✓ **The phrase now describes “the travelers”.**
- C** ✗ A semicolon cannot follow a fragment.
- D** ✗ “after the long flight.” is still a fragment.

TIP

- A descriptive phrase should sit right next to the person it describes.
- Fragment first + full sentence → attach with a comma.

TRAP

- Choosing the semicolon: same problem as the period.
- Deleting the word: “after the long flight.” is still a fragment.

9

Logical Separation of Ideas

Choose the mark that fits the RELATIONSHIP, not just the grammar.

Λογικός Διαχωρισμός Ιδεών

THEORY
5 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

This topic pulls together every punctuation rule so far. Several marks may be grammatical — only one correctly signals how the two ideas relate: explanation, addition, contrast, or a separate idea.

EXAMPLE

The result was clear: the experiment had failed.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Λογικός Διαχωρισμός Ιδεών

Η σωστή χρήση σημείων στίξης ώστε κάθε ιδέα να παρουσιάζεται καθαρά, χωρίς σύγχυση.

WHY IT MATTERS

- There is no single rule — combine clause skills and mark skills
- Ask: does part 2 explain, add, contrast, or stand apart?
- Often the hardest topic because grammar alone won't decide

Which mark fits which relationship?

RELATIONSHIP

EXAMPLE

WHY

Part 2 EXPLAINS or answers part 1 → colon

The result was clear: the experiment had failed.

A colon promises an explanation — and one follows.

Part 2 ADDS a related fact or effect → semicolon

The bridge was damaged; repairs began immediately.

Two closely related facts stay in one sentence.

Part 2 contrasts or continues → comma + FANBOYS

The bridge was damaged, but traffic kept moving.

The FANBOYS word names the relationship.

Part 2 is a separate idea → period

The bridge was damaged. The city is famous for its parks.

Unrelated ideas deserve their own sentences.

Right grammar, wrong relationship

RULE

WRONG EXAMPLE

WHY

Colon with nothing to explain

✗ *The bridge was damaged: the city is beautiful.*

The second part does not explain the first.

Semicolon + FANBOYS

✗ *The bridge was damaged; but traffic kept moving.*

Use a comma with FANBOYS.

Comma alone between full sentences

✗ *The bridge was damaged, repairs began immediately.*

Comma splice — also misses the relationship.

Choose the best mark

WRONG

✗ The forecast predicted rain, the picnic was cancelled.

✗ She had one goal, to win the title.

✗ The test was hard; but most students passed.

✗ The sun set: the market was crowded.

RIGHT



✓ The forecast predicted rain; the picnic was cancelled.



✓ She had one goal: to win the title.



✓ The test was hard, but most students passed.



✓ The sun set. The market was crowded.

WHY

Cause and effect: closely related → semicolon.

The second part explains the goal → colon.

Contrast with FANBOYS → comma.

Nothing is explained → separate sentences.

Ask these questions in order



Step 1 — Clauses

- Is each side independent or dependent?
- Fix any splice, run-on or fragment first

Step 2 — Relationship

- Explains / answers → colon
- Adds a related fact → semicolon
- Contrast or cause → comma + FANBOYS

Watch out

- A colon must deliver an explanation
- Don't pick a mark because it 'sounds' right
- If two marks both work, the question offers only one

Worked Example 9.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Scientists have long debated what caused the extinction, a massive asteroid impact is now widely accepted as the answer.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change the comma to a colon
- C remove the comma
- D change the comma to “and”

Worked Example 9.1: Solution

Answer: B — change the comma to a colon

PROCESS

1. Both sides are complete — so a plain comma will not do.
2. Ask how they relate: the second part ANSWERS the first.
3. A colon promises an explanation or an answer.
4. Change the comma to a colon.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Comma splice.
- B** ✓ **A colon: the second clause gives the answer to the debate.**
- C** ✗ Run-on.
- D** ✗ “and” makes the debate and the asteroid look like two items.

TIP

- Explains / answers / defines → colon.
- Just adds a related fact → semicolon.

TRAP

- Keeping the comma because it reads naturally.
- Thinking any connector will do — “and” garbles the meaning.

Worked Example 9.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The new bridge reduced commute times significantly, it also lowered fuel costs for daily commuters.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change the comma to a semicolon
- C change the comma to a colon
- D remove the comma

Worked Example 9.2: Solution

Answer: B — change the comma to a semicolon

PROCESS

1. Left and right are both complete → comma splice.
2. Relationship: the second part ADDS a related result.
3. It does not explain or define the first part.
4. A semicolon joins closely related facts.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Comma splice.
- B** ✓ **A semicolon links two related results.**
- C** ✗ A colon promises an explanation; “it also lowered...” only adds.
- D** ✗ Run-on.

TIP

- Ask: does part 2 explain part 1 (colon) or add to it (semicolon)?
- “Also” signals an added fact.

TRAP

- A colon feels sophisticated, but nothing is being explained.
- Removing the comma only makes it a run-on.

10

Parts of Speech

Name the job each word does.

Μέρη του Λόγου

THEORY
5 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

Parts of speech name the job a word does in a sentence. The test rarely asks about them directly — but subject-verb agreement, pronouns and modifiers all depend on spotting nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs fast.

EXAMPLE

the dog • the idea

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Μέρη του Λόγου

Οι κατηγορίες λέξεων ανάλογα με τη λειτουργία τους σε μια πρόταση (ουσιαστικό, ρήμα, επίθετο, κ.λπ.).

WHY IT MATTERS

- Nouns and verbs build every sentence
- Adjectives describe nouns; adverbs describe actions and qualities
- One word can do different jobs in different sentences



Quick tests for each part

PART	EXAMPLE	QUICK TEST
Noun — a person, place, thing or idea	<i>the dog • the idea</i>	Can it follow “the”?
Verb — an action or state	<i>he runs • they think</i>	Can it follow a subject pronoun (he, they)?
Adjective — describes a noun	<i>The bright red car caught our attention.</i>	Answers “what kind?” or “which one?”
Adverb — describes a verb, adjective or adverb	<i>She sang beautifully.</i>	Answers “how?”, “when?” or “to what extent?”



Label the sentence

“The bright red car stopped suddenly.”

WORD	PART OF SPEECH	CLUE
car	Noun	It names the thing; it follows “the bright red”.
bright • red	Adjectives	They describe the noun “car”.
stopped	Verb	It is what the car DID.
suddenly	Adverb	It tells HOW the car stopped.

Where students get caught

**CASE****EXAMPLE****WHY**

-ly does not always mean adverb

friendly • lonely • lovely

These are adjectives that happen to end in -ly.

Some adverbs have no -ly

fast • hard • well

“He worked hard all summer.” — hard describes worked.

One word, different jobs

I run daily. / a home run

“Run” is a verb in the first, a noun in the second.

Parts of speech in three lines



Find the job

- Ask what the word DOES in THIS sentence
- Not what it looks like

Adjective or adverb?

- Describes a noun → adjective
- Describes an action, adjective or adverb → adverb

Watch out

- Don't decide by the -ly ending
- The same word can switch jobs
- Look at the neighbouring words

Worked Example 10.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The scientist's careful analysis revealed a surprising pattern in the data.

What part of speech is "careful" in this sentence?

A a noun

B a verb

C an adjective

D an adverb

Worked Example 10.1: Solution

Answer: C — an adjective

PROCESS

1. Ask what “careful” describes: the word “analysis”.
2. “Analysis” is a noun.
3. A word that describes a noun is an adjective.
4. So “careful” tells us what KIND of analysis it was.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A noun names a thing; “careful” describes one.
- B** ✗ “Careful” shows no action.
- C** ✓ **It describes the noun “analysis”.**
- D** ✗ The adverb would be “carefully” and would describe an action.

TIP

- Adjective test: does it answer “what kind?” or “which one?”
- Adverb test: does it answer “how?”, “when?” or “how much?”

TRAP

- Choosing adverb because “careful” sounds like “carefully”.
- Thinking every describing word is an adverb.

Worked Example 10.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The runners moved quickly toward the finish line as the crowd cheered loudly.

What parts of speech are “quickly” and “loudly”?

A both are adjectives

B both are adverbs

C “quickly” is an adjective; “loudly” is an adverb

D “quickly” is an adverb; “loudly” is an adjective

Worked Example 10.2: Solution

Answer: B — both are adverbs

PROCESS

1. “Quickly” — what does it describe? The verb “moved”: HOW they moved.
2. “Loudly” — describes the verb “cheered”: HOW the crowd cheered.
3. Words that describe verbs are adverbs.
4. Both end in -ly, which confirms it.

TIP

- Ask “how?” — a word that answers it about an action is an adverb.
- -ly is a clue, not a guarantee (“friendly” is an adjective).

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Neither word describes a noun.
- B** ✓ **Both describe verbs (how).**
- C** ✗ “Quickly” describes “moved”, not a noun.
- D** ✗ “Loudly” describes “cheered”, not a noun.

TRAP

- Assuming every -ly word is an adverb: “friendly”, “lonely”, “lovely” are adjectives.
- Mixing the two up because they sound alike.

11

Verbs & Tenses

Tense tells WHEN. Form tells the JOB.

Ρήματα και Χρόνοι

THEORY
7 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

Verb tense tells the reader WHEN an action happened. The Digital SAT checks whether a sentence stays consistent in tense — or shifts only when the timeline truly changes — and whether the verb has the right FORM for its job.

EXAMPLE

She walked to school and greeted her friends.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Ρήματα και Χρόνοι

Ο χρόνος ενός ρήματος δείχνει ΠΟΤΕ συνέβη μια ενέργεια (παρελθόν, παρόν, μέλλον).

WHY IT MATTERS

- The most common trap: a tense shift for no reason
- Time clues (dates, since, for, already) decide the tense
- Every clause needs exactly one main (finite) verb

Three tense patterns

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Keep tense consistent unless the timeline changes

She walked to school and greeted her friends.

Both actions happened in the past.

Present perfect: started in the past, continues now

She has lived in Athens for ten years.

“Has lived” links past to present; “lived” would mean finished.

Past perfect: completed BEFORE another past action

By the time the movie started, we had already eaten.

“Had eaten” shows which past event came first.

Four rules worth memorizing

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

WILL = real future; WOULD = hypothetical or reported

If you study, you will pass. • He said he would call.

“Would” looks back or imagines.

Subjunctive: demand / insist / recommend + THAT + base verb

The committee recommended that the budget BE reduced.

The base form is used, not “is”.

Contrary-to-fact “if”: use WERE

If I were you, I would reconsider.

“Were” marks something unreal.

Active voice when both work

The team conducted the experiment.

Active names who acts — clearer and shorter.



Main verbs vs. other verb forms

FORM	EXAMPLE	JOB
Finite (main) verb	<i>The committee decided.</i>	Has a subject and tense; one per clause.
To-infinitive	<i>The committee decided to include tug-of-war.</i>	Follows verbs of intention: decide, plan, hope, want.
Past participle	<i>Created by Brown, the saloon was famous.</i>	Passive or describing; NOT a main verb on its own.
-ing form	<i>Including tug-of-war, the committee surprised fans.</i>	Describes a noun, or acts as one.

Three verb errors

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
Shifting tense for no reason	✗ <i>She walked into the room and sees her friend.</i>	Past “walked” suddenly becomes present “sees”.
“Was” in a contrary-to-fact clause	✗ <i>If I was you, I would reconsider.</i>	An unreal “if” takes “were”.
Wrong form after “recommend that”	✗ <i>The committee recommended that the budget is reduced.</i>	Subjunctive needs the base form “be”.

Spot the verb error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ Since 2010, she lived in Athens.

✗ The board demanded that she resigns.

✗ We had finished dinner when the guests had arrived.

✗ Creating by Brown, the saloon was famous.

RIGHT

✓ Since 2010, she has lived in Athens.

✓ The board demanded that she resign.

✓ We had finished dinner when the guests arrived.

✓ Created by Brown, the saloon was famous.

WHY

“Since” signals present perfect.

Subjunctive: base form after “demanded that”.

Earlier action → past perfect; later action → simple past.

“By” + agent → past participle.

Verbs in three lines

Find the anchor

- Read the whole passage
- Find the anchor tense
- Match every verb unless time truly changes

Time clues

- since · for · already → present or past perfect
- Dates in the past → simple past
- Two past events → earlier one gets “had”

Watch out

- Main verb already there?
The blank is a verb FORM
- Verbs of intention take to + verb
- Active voice when both are correct

Worked Example 11.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

The Boston Saloon was one of the most popular African American-owned establishments in nineteenth-century Nevada. _____ by businessman William A.G. Brown, the saloon was known to offer elegant accommodations and an inclusive environment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A Created

B Creates

C Creating

D Create

Worked Example 11.1: Solution

Answer: A — Created

PROCESS

1. The sentence already has a main verb: “was known”.
2. So the blank cannot be a second main (finite) verb.
3. The opening phrase must describe “the saloon”.
4. The saloon was created BY Brown — a passive idea → past participle “Created”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A ✓** Past participle: “Created by Brown” describes the saloon.
- B ✗** A second main verb with no conjunction.
- C ✗** “Creating” makes the saloon the creator, clashing with “by Brown”.
- D ✗** A base-form main verb: ungrammatical here.

TIP

- Main verb already there? The blank is a verb FORM, not a second verb.
- “by + a person” signals the passive: use the past participle.

TRAP

- “Creating” sounds natural in an intro phrase — but it would mean the saloon created Brown.
- Picking a present-tense verb from habit.

Worked Example 11.2



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

Nowadays, tug-of-war is usually seen as an informal game one might play at a picnic or in gym class. Surprisingly, the Olympic committee once decided _____ tug-of-war as an official Olympic event! Nations competed in the event at the Olympic Games from 1900 to 1920.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A included

B including

C include

D to include

11

Worked Example 11.2: Solution

Answer: D — to include

PROCESS

1. The main verb is already “decided”.
2. “Decide” takes an infinitive: decide + TO + verb.
3. So the blank needs “to include”.
4. Check: “decided to include tug-of-war” says WHAT they decided.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Past tense creates a second main verb.
- B** ✗ “decided including” is not a standard pattern.
- C** ✗ The “to” is missing.
- D** ✓ **“decided to include” — verb + infinitive.**

TIP

- Learn the “to” verbs: decide, plan, hope, agree, refuse, want, need.
- After a verb of intention, think infinitive.

TRAP

- “include” looks fine until you notice the missing “to”.
- “including” feels smooth because it ends in -ing.

12

Subject-Verb Agreement

One basic rule, many disguises.

Συμφωνία Υποκειμένου-Ρήματος

THEORY
8 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
7 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

Singular subjects take singular verbs; plural subjects take plural verbs. The Digital SAT tests this simple rule through many disguises — extra phrases, tricky nouns, pairs of subjects, and reversed word order.

EXAMPLE

The teacher and the principal are meeting today.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Συμφωνία Υποκειμένου-Ρήματος

Ένα ενικό υποκείμενο χρειάζεται ενικό ρήμα. Ένα πληθυντικό υποκείμενο χρειάζεται πληθυντικό ρήμα.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Find the TRUE subject first, then match the verb
- Cross out phrases between subject and verb
- Present tense: singular verbs end in -s (she runs), plural do not (they run)

“And” vs. “or / nor”

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Subjects joined by AND are plural

The teacher and the principal are meeting today.

Two singular subjects together make a plural.

Exception: AND naming ONE thing is singular

Macaroni and cheese is my favorite meal.

It names a single dish.

OR / NOR / either...or / neither...nor: match the CLOSER subject

Either the manager or the employees are responsible.

“Employees” is nearest the verb.

Swap the order and the verb changes

Either the employees or the manager is responsible.

Now “manager” is nearest.

Intervening and additive phrases

Intervening phrases

- Sit between subject and verb
- Often start with of, with, in, including
- Verb agrees with the TRUE subject
- The keys to the cabinet ARE missing

Additive phrases

- along with • as well as
- in addition to • together with
- They do NOT make a subject plural
- The manager, along with her team, IS attending

The cross-out trick

- Cross out the whole phrase
- Read subject + verb together
- The photos (in the old album) IS faded → ARE

Collective, always-singular and always-plural nouns

Collective nouns → singular

- team • family • jury • committee
- The committee **MEETS** every Tuesday
- Plural only if members act separately

Look plural, ARE singular

- Subjects: mathematics, economics, physics
- Disease: measles
- News • The United States

Look singular, ARE plural

- scissors • pants • glasses
- tweezers • binoculars • shorts
- “A pair of scissors” **IS** singular

Singular, plural, or it depends

Always singular

- each • either • neither
- everyone • everybody • everything
- someone • anyone • no one • nobody
- Everyone HAS finished

Always plural

- both • few • many • several
- Both of the answers ARE correct
- Few of the applicants WERE qualified

Depends on the noun

- some • all • most • none • any
- Most of the cake WAS eaten (uncountable)
- Most of the cookies WERE eaten (countable)

Four more patterns

RULE**EXAMPLE****WHY**

“The number of” = singular; “A number of” = plural

The number of applicants HAS grown. • A number of applicants HAVE applied.

“A number of” means “several”.

There is / there are: the subject comes AFTER the verb

There ARE several solutions to this problem.

“There” is never the subject.

Amounts, distances and times are singular

Five years IS a long time to wait.

One unit, not five separate years.

A gerund subject is singular

Reading books IS one of her hobbies.

“-ing” subjects count as one activity.

Spot the agreement error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The list of ingredients are on the counter.

✗ Neither of the options seem ideal.

✗ The pilot, together with the crew, were praised.

✗ There is several reasons for the delay.

RIGHT

✓ The list of ingredients is on the counter.

✓ Neither of the options seems ideal.

✓ The pilot, together with the crew, was praised.

✓ There are several reasons for the delay.

WHY

True subject: “list”.

“Neither” is singular.

“Together with” does not add a plural subject.

Subject follows the verb: “reasons”.

Agreement in three lines



Step 1 — Find the subject

- Cross out phrases between subject and verb
- Cross out “of + noun” and “along with...”

Step 2 — Singular or plural?

- AND → plural
- OR / NOR → closer subject
- The number of → singular
A number of → plural

Watch out

- The noun nearest the verb is often NOT the subject
- Check the MEANING of tricky nouns
- “There is / are”: look AFTER the verb

Worked Example 12.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

From 1912 to 1951, Charlotta Bass owned and operated the newspaper The California Eagle. While it was under Bass's leadership, The Eagle _____ one of the US's most influential Black-owned newspapers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A will become

B became

C is becoming

D to become

Worked Example 12.1: Solution

Answer: B — became

PROCESS

1. Find the time clues: “From 1912 to 1951” and “was under Bass’s leadership”.
2. The other verbs (owned, operated, was) are past tense.
3. The blank needs a past-tense main verb.
4. “The Eagle became...” — singular subject, past tense.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Future tense: the events are over.
- B** ✓ **Simple past: matches owned, operated, was.**
- C** ✗ Present progressive for a finished period.
- D** ✗ An infinitive: no main verb in the clause.

TIP

- Match the tense of the surrounding verbs unless the timeline changes.
- Dates in the past = past tense.

TRAP

- “is becoming” feels like a story told in the present.
- “to become” has no tense: the clause would lack a main verb.

Worked Example 12.2



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

Farouk El-Baz, a geologist and space scientist,
_____ part of the team that selected the lunar
landing sites for the Apollo program during the
1960s and 1970s.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A are

B was

C have been

D were

12

Worked Example 12.2: Solution

Answer: B — was

PROCESS

1. Find the subject: “Farouk El-Baz” — one person.
2. “a geologist and space scientist” sits between commas — cross it out.
3. Singular subject + past time (1960s–1970s) → singular past verb.
4. “Farouk El-Baz ... was part of the team”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Plural, present tense.
- B** ✓ **Singular, past tense.**
- C** ✗ Plural present perfect.
- D** ✗ Plural, past tense.

TIP

- Cross out the commas-phrase to see subject and verb side by side.
- One person = singular, even when his job title contains “and”.

TRAP

- “geologist and space scientist” contains “and” — it lures you to a plural verb.
- The nearest words (“scientist”) are not the subject.

Worked Example 12.3



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The committee, along with the department heads, is finalizing next year's budget.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** change “is” to “are”
- C** change “committee” to “committees”
- D** change “is” to “were”

Worked Example 12.3: Solution

Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. Find the true subject: “The committee”.
2. “along with the department heads” is an additive phrase between commas.
3. Additive phrases do not make the subject plural — only “and” does.
4. Singular subject + “is” — correct.

TIP

- Cross it out: “The committee ... is finalizing”.
- along with / as well as / in addition to / together with = additive, not plural.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ “Committee” is singular; “is” agrees.
- B** ✗ A plural verb for a singular subject.
- C** ✗ Changes the subject, and “is” would then clash.
- D** ✗ Plural, and the tense shifts to the past.

TRAP

- Counting “heads” as part of the subject.
- Changing the noun instead of checking the verb.

Worked Example 12.4



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Neither the witnesses nor the defendant was able to recall the exact time of the incident.

Which choice is best?

A is correct as written

B change “was” to “were”

C change “neither” to “either”

D change “defendant” to “defendants”

Worked Example 12.4: Solution

Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. “Neither ... nor” joins two subjects: witnesses (plural) and defendant (singular).
2. With or / nor, the verb agrees with the CLOSER subject.
3. Closest to the verb: “the defendant” — singular.
4. “Was” is correct.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ The verb agrees with “defendant”, the closer subject.
- B** ✗ “Were” agrees with the farther subject.
- C** ✗ “either ... nor” is not a pair.
- D** ✗ With a plural “defendants” the singular “was” would clash.

TIP

- With or / nor, look only at the subject nearest the verb.
- Swap the order to test: “Neither the defendant nor the witnesses were...”

TRAP

- Choosing “were” because the first subject is plural.
- Treating “neither ... nor” like “and”.

Worked Example 12.5



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

A number of employees has already submitted feedback about the new policy.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “has” to “have”
- C change “employees” to “employee”
- D change “number” to “amount”

12

Worked Example 12.5: Solution

Answer: B — change “has” to “have”

PROCESS

1. Spot the phrase “a number of”.
2. It works like “several” — always plural.
3. A plural subject needs a plural verb: “have”.
4. Compare: “THE number of employees HAS increased.”

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ “Has” is singular.
- B** ✓ “A number of employees have” — plural.
- C** ✗ “A number of employee” is ungrammatical.
- D** ✗ “Amount” is for uncountable things, not employees.

TIP

- A number of = plural. THE number of = singular.
- Swap in “several”: “Several employees have...”

TRAP

- Seeing “number” (singular) and choosing “has”.
- Changing the noun instead of the verb.

Worked Example 12.6



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The pair of scissors on the desk belong to the art teacher.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “belong” to “belongs”
- C change “scissors” to “scissor”
- D change “desk” to “desks”

Worked Example 12.6: Solution

Answer: B — change “belong” to “belongs”

PROCESS

1. Cross out the phrases: “of scissors” and “on the desk”.
2. True subject: “The pair” — singular.
3. “Pair” is singular even though “scissors” is plural in form.
4. Singular subject → “belongs”.

TIP

- “A pair of ...” is always singular.
- Cross out “of + noun” to find the real subject.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A plural verb for the singular “pair”.
- B** ✓ **“Pair ... belongs”.**
- C** ✗ Changing the noun leaves the verb mismatch.
- D** ✗ Irrelevant to the subject-verb match.

TRAP

- The plural “scissors” or the nearby “desk” pulls you toward “belong”.
- “Scissors” alone IS plural — but it is not the subject here.

Worked Example 12.7



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

There is, according to recent studies, several factors that influence student performance.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “is” to “are”
- C change “several” to “a single”
- D change “factors” to “factor”

12

Worked Example 12.7: Solution

Answer: B — change “is” to “are”

PROCESS

1. “There is / are” flips the order: the subject comes **AFTER** the verb.
2. Cross out “according to recent studies”.
3. True subject: “several factors” — plural.
4. A plural subject → “There are ... several factors”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ “Is” is singular; the subject is plural.
- B** ✓ **“There are ... several factors”.**
- C** ✗ “a single factors” is ungrammatical.
- D** ✗ “several factor” is ungrammatical.

TIP

- Flip it to hear the agreement: “Several factors are...”
- “There” is never the subject.

TRAP

- “studies” sits next to the blank and feels like the subject.
- Changing the noun to match the verb instead of the verb to match the noun.

13

Pronouns

Every pronoun needs a clear, matching antecedent.

Αντωνυμίες

THEORY
8 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
3 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A pronoun (he, she, it, they, this, which) stands in for a noun called its ANTECEDENT. The Digital SAT tests two things: does the pronoun MATCH its antecedent in number, and is it CLEAR which noun it refers to?

EXAMPLE

The company announced its new policy.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Αντωνυμίες

Λέξεις που αντικαθιστούν ένα ουσιαστικό, όπως “αυτός”, “αυτή” ή “αυτοί”.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Find the antecedent FIRST
- Singular noun → singular pronoun; plural noun → plural pronoun
- A pronoun can also point back to a whole idea



Three pronoun rules

RULE	EXAMPLE	WHY
Match the antecedent in number	<i>The company announced its new policy.</i>	“Company” is singular, so “its”.
Make the antecedent clear	✗ <i>When Sarah met Ana, she brought a gift.</i>	“She” could be Sarah or Ana — name the person.
Who for people; which / that for things	<i>The scientist who found the pattern published her results.</i>	“Who” refers to a person.



Look-alike pairs

RULE	EXAMPLE	TEST
WHO = subject (does the action)	<i>The scientist WHO discovered the compound...</i>	Replace with he / she → who.
WHOM = object (receives the action)	<i>The researcher WHOM they selected...</i>	Replace with him / her → whom.
ITS = possessive • IT'S = it is	<i>The machine lost ITS power. • IT'S a hard problem.</i>	Replace with “it is” — works? it's.
WHOSE = possessive • WHO'S = who is	<i>The scientist WHOSE theory changed physics...</i>	Replace with “who is” — works? who's.

“That” and “which”: essential or extra?

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHAT IT MEANS

THAT = essential information → NO commas

The book that I borrowed was great.

“That I borrowed” tells WHICH book. Remove it and the meaning changes.

WHICH = non-essential (extra) information → commas on BOTH sides

The book, which I borrowed last week, was great.

“Which...” only adds a detail. Remove it and the sentence still works.

WHO = people, in either kind of clause

The teacher who helped me moved. • My teacher, who helped me, moved.

“Who” never changes; the commas show essential or extra.

The test: cross the clause out

Does the sentence still point to the SAME thing?

Yes → extra → which + commas. No → essential → that, no commas.

Spot the that / which error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The book, that I borrowed, was great.

✗ My car that is ten years old still runs.

✗ The scientist which won the prize is Greek.

✗ The bridge, that connects the towns, is old.

RIGHT

→ ✓ The book that I borrowed was great.

→ ✓ My car, which is ten years old, still runs.

→ ✓ The scientist who won the prize is Greek.

→ ✓ The bridge, which connects the towns, is old.

WHY

Essential → “that”, no commas.

I have one car; the age is extra → which + commas.

People take “who”, not “which”.

Extra information needs “which”.

Three pronoun errors

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
Plural noun, singular pronoun	✗ <i>She copied 800 of her poems into booklets and numbered it.</i>	“Poems” is plural — use “them”.
Ambiguous reference	✗ <i>The coach told the player he was tired.</i>	“He” could be either one.
Singular antecedent, plural pronoun	✗ <i>The committee announced their decision.</i>	“Committee” acts as one unit — use “its”.

Spot the pronoun error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The company revealed it's plans.

✗ Dickinson copied 800 poems; she numbered it.

✗ The researcher who they chose published her study.

✗ Minh became secretary-general, making these a first.

RIGHT

→ ✓ The company revealed its plans.

→ ✓ Dickinson copied 800 poems; she numbered them.

→ ✓ The researcher whom they chose published her study.

→ ✓ Minh became secretary-general, making this a first.

WHY

"It's" = "it is"; possession needs "its".

Plural antecedent → plural pronoun.

"Whom" is the object of "chose".

"This" points to ONE event.

Pronouns in three lines



Step 1 — Antecedent

- Circle the noun the pronoun replaces
- Or the whole idea it points back to

Step 2 — Match

- Singular ↔ singular
- Plural ↔ plural
- One whole event → this / that

Watch out

- Could it refer to two nouns? → ambiguous
- Test it's / who's with "it is" / "who is"
- Groups (company, committee) are singular

Worked Example 13.1



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

American poet Emily Dickinson wrote many of her poems on scraps of paper, but she also took steps to collect these works. From 1858 to around 1864, for example, she copied more than 800 of _____ into forty homemade booklets (known as fascicles).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A them

B this

C that

D it

Worked Example 13.1: Solution

Answer: A — them

PROCESS

1. Ask what the pronoun stands for: her poems / these works.
2. Those nouns are plural.
3. So the pronoun must be plural too.
4. Only “them” is plural: “800 of them”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A ✓ A plural pronoun for the plural “poems”.**
- B ✗ A singular pronoun.**
- C ✗ A singular pronoun.**
- D ✗ A singular pronoun.**

TIP

- Find the antecedent FIRST, then check the number.
- “800 of ____” points back to a plural group.

TRAP

- “This” or “that” feel natural, but both are singular.
- “It” sounds right if you picture one work.

Worked Example 13.2



REAL COLLEGE BOARD QUESTION

Lê Lương Minh became the thirteenth secretary-general of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in January 2013, making _____ the first time the organization would appoint a Vietnamese leader.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A these

B those

C this

D some

13

Worked Example 13.2: Solution

Answer: C — this

PROCESS

1. Ask what the blank points back to: the whole event of his appointment.
2. That event is ONE thing — singular.
3. “This” is the singular pronoun that can point to a whole clause.
4. “...making this the first time...”

TIP

- A pronoun can refer to a whole previous idea, not only to a noun.
- One event → this / that (singular).

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ A plural pronoun.
- B** ✗ A plural pronoun.
- C** ✓ **A singular pronoun for one event.**
- D** ✗ “Some” is a quantity word with no antecedent.

TRAP

- “these” or “those”: plural pronouns for a singular event.
- “some” does not refer to anything specific.

Worked Example 13.3



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The bridge, that connects the two towns, was built in 1932.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “that” to “which”
- C change “that” to “who”
- D change “that” to “what”

Worked Example 13.3: Solution

Answer: B — change “that” to “which”

PROCESS

1. Find the clause between the commas: “that connects the two towns”.
2. Cross it out: “The bridge was built in 1932.” still works.
3. So it is extra (non-essential) information.
4. Extra information takes “which” with commas on both sides.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ “That” is for essential information and never takes commas.
- B** ✓ **“Which” fits extra information set off by commas.**
- C** ✗ “Who” is for people.
- D** ✗ “What” cannot introduce a clause that describes a noun.

TIP

- Commas around a clause → use WHICH.
- No commas around a clause → use THAT.

TRAP

- Keeping “that” because it sounds natural in speech.
- Choosing “who”: a bridge is a thing, not a person.

14

Nouns & Apostrophes

Possession or contraction — nothing else.

Ουσιαστικά και Απόστροφες

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

Apostrophes have exactly TWO jobs: showing possession (something belongs to someone) or forming a contraction (two words squeezed into one). They are never used to make a simple plural.

EXAMPLE

The student's book was on the desk.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Ουσιαστικά και Απόστροφοι

Η απόστροφος δείχνει κτήση (σε ποιον ανήκει κάτι) ή αντικαθιστά γράμματα σε συντομογραφίες.

WHY IT MATTERS

- The test mixes up plurals, possessives and contractions
- The apostrophe goes AFTER the owner
- Count vs. non-count nouns also live here



Apostrophe rules

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Singular possession: 's

The student's book was on the desk.

ONE student owns the book.

Plural possession ending in s: s'

The students' books were returned.

MANY students; "students" already ends in s.

Contraction: replaces missing letters

It's raining outside.

"It's" = "it is".

ITS (possessive) has NO apostrophe

The dog wagged its tail.

Like his, her and their.

Three apostrophe errors

RULE

WRONG EXAMPLE

WHY

An apostrophe to make a plural

✗ *I bought three apple's.*

A simple plural needs no apostrophe.

it's for its

✗ *The company announced it's new policy.*

“It is new policy” makes no sense.

An apostrophe in a decade

✗ *the 1990's*

Write 1990s — no possession.

Fewer or less? Many or much?

RULE**EXAMPLE****WHY**

COUNT nouns → many, fewer, a number of

fewer errors • many experiments

You can count them.

NON-COUNT nouns → much, less, an amount of

less water • much advice

You cannot count them.

The classic mistake

✗ *less errors* → ✓ *fewer errors*

“Errors” can be counted.

Spot the apostrophe error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The committees decision surprised us (one committee).

✗ The dogs toys were scattered (several dogs).

✗ The cat licked it's paw.

✗ We sold three bag's of flour.

RIGHT

→ ✓ The committee's decision surprised us.

→ ✓ The dogs' toys were scattered.

→ ✓ The cat licked its paw.

→ ✓ We sold three bags of flour.

WHY

Singular possession.

Plural possession: apostrophe after the s.

Possessive "its" has no apostrophe.

Plural, not possession.

Apostrophes in three lines



Ask two questions

- Does it show OWNERSHIP?
- One owner or several?

Placement

- One owner → owner + 's
- Several owners ending in s → s'
- Plural only → no apostrophe

Watch out

- it's = it is • its = belongs to it
- Decades: 1990s
- Fewer = countable • less = uncountable

Worked Example 14.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The committees decision, announced late Friday, surprised several members of that committee.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “committees” to “committee’s”
- C change “committees” to “committees’”
- D change “decision” to “decisions”

Worked Example 14.1: Solution

Answer: B — change “committees” to “committee’s”

PROCESS

1. “committees decision” — the decision belongs to the committee: possession.
2. Possession needs an apostrophe.
3. “...of that committee” shows there is ONE committee → singular.
4. Singular possessive: apostrophe + s → “committee’s”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Possession shown with no apostrophe.
- B** ✓ **One committee owns the decision.**
- C** ✗ That would mean several committees.
- D** ✗ Changing the noun does not fix the missing possessive.

TIP

- Ask: who owns it? One owner or several?
- One owner: 's. Several owners already ending in s: s'.

TRAP

- “committees’” is the plural possessive — but the sentence names one committee.
- Leaving it because a plural “committees” looks fine.

Worked Example 14.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The company revealed it's plans for expansion into three new countries.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change "it's" to "its"
- C change "it's" to "its'"
- D change "plans" to "plan's"

14

Worked Example 14.2: Solution

Answer: B — change “it’s” to “its”

PROCESS

1. Test “it’s” = “it is”: “The company revealed it is plans” — nonsense.
2. So this is not a contraction.
3. We need possession: the plans belong to the company.
4. The possessive of “it” has no apostrophe: “its”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ “it’s” means “it is”.
- B** ✓ **“its” is the possessive.**
- C** ✗ “its’” is never correct.
- D** ✗ “plan’s” adds a false possessive and leaves “it’s” wrong.

TIP

- Replace with “it is”. Does it work? No → use “its”.
- Its = possessive, like his / her / their.

TRAP

- Applying “apostrophe + s = possession” to the word “it”.
- “its’” — this word does not exist.

15

Adjectives & Adverbs

Describes a noun? Adjective. Describes an action? Adverb.

Επίθετα και Επιδόματα

THEORY
6 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
2 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

The most common error tested here is using an adjective where an adverb is needed — or the reverse. It usually happens right after a verb: if the word describes the SUBJECT, use an adjective; if it describes HOW the action happens, use an adverb.

WRONG EXAMPLE

She ran quick to catch the bus.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Επίθετα και Επιδράματα

Τα επίθετα περιγράφουν ουσιαστικά. Τα επιρρήματα περιγράφουν ρήματα, επίθετα, ή άλλα επιρρήματα.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Linking verbs (is, seems, feels) → adjectives
- Action verbs + “how?” → adverbs
- Comparisons add two more checks: 2 vs. 3+, and commas between adjectives

Adjective vs. adverb errors

RULE**WRONG EXAMPLE****WHY**

An adjective describing an action

✗ *She ran quick to catch the bus.*

“Quick” describes HOW she ran → quickly.

“Good” instead of “well”

✗ *He played the piano good.*

“Good” is an adjective; “well” describes the action.

An adverb after a linking verb

✗ *The plan seems reasonably.*

After seems / is / feels use an adjective: reasonable.

Count the things

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Comparing 2 things → comparative (-er / more)

Of the two methods, this one is MORE effective.

Two things → comparative.

Comparing 3+ things → superlative (-est / most)

Of the three candidates, she is THE MOST qualified.

Three or more → superlative.

Double forms are ALWAYS wrong

✗ *more easier* • ✗ *most highest*

One marker is enough: easier, highest.

Coordinate vs. non-coordinate adjectives

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

COORDINATE: insert “and” or reverse the order → comma

a long, difficult exam

“Long and difficult” works; “difficult, long” works.

NON-COORDINATE: “and” sounds wrong → NO comma

a beautiful Italian dress

“Beautiful and Italian dress” sounds wrong.

Redundant adjectives repeat the noun’s meaning

✗ *final conclusion* • ✗ *past history*

The noun already says it.

Spot the error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The negotiations proceeded smooth.

✗ She explained the plan clear.

✗ Of the two designs, this is the best.

✗ She wore a red, silk scarf.

RIGHT

→ ✓ The negotiations proceeded smoothly.

→ ✓ She explained the plan clearly.

→ ✓ Of the two designs, this is the better.

→ ✓ She wore a red silk scarf.

WHY

Describes HOW → adverb.

Action verb → adverb.

Two things → comparative.

*Non-coordinate adjectives
take no comma.*

Adjectives & adverbs in three lines

Choose by the verb

- Linking verb (is, seems, feels, looks) → adjective
- Action verb + “how?” → adverb

Choose by the count

- 2 things → -er / more
- 3 or more → -est / most
- Never both: × more easier

Watch out

- Good = adjective • Well = adverb
- Comma test: can you reverse or add “and”?
- Redundant: final conclusion, past history

Worked Example 15.1



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The negotiations proceeded smooth once both sides agreed to the new terms.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** change “smooth” to “smoothly”
- C** change “proceeded” to “proceed”
- D** change “agreed” to “agree”

Worked Example 15.1: Solution

Answer: B — change “smooth” to “smoothly”

PROCESS

1. Ask what “smooth” describes: HOW the negotiations proceeded.
2. “Proceeded” is an action verb.
3. How an action happens → adverb.
4. “Smooth” → “smoothly”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ An adjective cannot describe an action.
- B** ✓ The adverb “smoothly” describes “proceeded”.
- C** ✗ A tense change does not address the error.
- D** ✗ “agree” breaks the past-tense pattern.

TIP

- Action verb + “how?” → adverb.
- Linking verb (is, seems, feels) + description of the subject → adjective.

TRAP

- “Smooth” sounds fine in casual speech.
- Changing a verb tense when the problem is the describing word.

Worked Example 15.2



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Of the three finalists, she performed the most impressively during the final round.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “most impressively” to “more impressively”
- C change “most impressively” to “most impressive”
- D change “performed” to “performs”

15

Worked Example 15.2: Solution

Answer: A — is correct as written

PROCESS

1. Count the group: three finalists → 3 or more → superlative.
2. “Most impressively” is the superlative adverb.
3. “Performed” is an action verb, so an adverb is right.
4. Everything checks out — no change.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✓ The superlative adverb for three or more.
- B** ✗ The comparative is for two things.
- C** ✗ An adjective cannot describe the verb.
- D** ✗ Present tense clashes with “during the final round”.

TIP

- Count the things: 2 → -er / more. 3+ → -est / most.
- Action verb + “how?” → adverb.

TRAP

- Choosing “more” out of habit.
- Switching to “impressive”: an adjective cannot describe how she performed.

16

Modifiers

Every modifier must sit next to what it describes.

Προσδιοριστές (Modifiers)

THEORY
7 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
4 questions

The big idea



WHAT IT IS

A modifier is any word or phrase whose only job is to describe, limit or add detail to another word. The one habit that solves most questions: for every modifier ask, “Exactly which word does this describe — and is that word right next to it?”

EXAMPLE

the nervous student • three loud dogs

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Προσδιοριστές (Modifiers)

Μια λέξη ή φράση που περιγράφει κάτι άλλο στην πρόταση — πρέπει να βρίσκεται κοντά σε αυτό που περιγράφει.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Adjectives modify nouns and pronouns
- Adverbs modify verbs, adjectives and other adverbs
- Phrases can modify too — and must sit close to their target

Types of modifiers



MODIFIER	EXAMPLE	WHAT IT DESCRIBES
Adjective	<i>the nervous student • three loud dogs</i>	A noun or pronoun: what kind? which one? how many?
Adverb (on a verb)	<i>She spoke quietly.</i>	A verb: how, when, where?
Adverb (on an adjective or adverb)	<i>an extremely difficult exam • very quickly</i>	Degree or extent of another descriptor.
Modifying phrase	<i>the man in the blue jacket • Smiling broadly, she accepted the award.</i>	A noun or the subject: prepositional, participial or appositive phrases.

The noun after the comma must DO the action

RULE

The subject right after the comma must match the phrase

EXAMPLE

Exhausted from the flight, the travelers went to bed.

WHY

Travelers CAN be exhausted.

Wrong subject = dangling modifier

✗ *Exhausted from the flight, the hotel room felt wonderful.*

A hotel room cannot be exhausted.

Fix: put the right noun after the comma

Exhausted from the flight, the travelers loved their room.

The phrase now has a logical subject.

An ending modifier describes what comes **BEFORE** it

RULE	EXAMPLE	WHY
No comma: it describes the closest word before it	<i>The waiter served the man a steak wrapped in foil.</i>	“Wrapped in foil” describes “steak”, the word right before it.
Comma + -ing phrase: it describes the whole clause before it	<i>The lights went out, leaving us in the dark.</i>	“Leaving us in the dark” describes what happened.
Too far from its target = misplaced	✗ <i>She gave the toy to the child wrapped in plastic.</i>	It sounds like the CHILD is wrapped in plastic.
Fix: put it right after the word it describes	<i>She gave the child the toy wrapped in plastic.</i>	Now the phrase sits next to “toy”.

Misplaced, dangling and squinting

ERROR**EXAMPLE****FIX****MISPLACED: too far from its target**

✗ *The waiter served a steak to the man wrapped in foil.*

The waiter served the man a steak wrapped in foil.

DANGLING: the target is missing

✗ *After finishing the report, the computer was shut down.*

After finishing the report, she shut down the computer.

SQUINTING: could describe either side

✗ *Students who practice frequently improve.*

Move it beside ONE word: Students who frequently practice improve.

Spot the modifier error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ Covered in dust, Maria found the old photographs.

✗ She only ate vegetables for dinner.

✗ Having finished dinner, the dishes were washed.

✗ Employees who leave early often receive a warning.

RIGHT

→
✓ Maria found the old photographs covered in dust.

→
✓ She ate only vegetables for dinner.

→
✓ Having finished dinner, we washed the dishes.

→
✓ Employees who often leave early receive a warning.

WHY

The photographs were dusty, not Maria.

“Only” belongs next to “vegetables”.

Dishes cannot finish dinner.

Place “often” beside the one word it describes.

Modifiers in three lines



The core question

- What EXACTLY does this describe?
- Is that word right next to it?

Intro phrases

- Check the noun after the comma
- Can it do or be what the phrase says?
- No? → dangling modifier

Watch out

- Place only / almost / often with care
- An ending modifier describes the word BEFORE it
- Don't fix the verb when the problem is position



Worked Example 16.1

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Rushing to catch the train, the bags were left behind at the platform.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B rewrite as “Rushing to catch the train, she left the bags behind at the platform.”
- C change “Rushing” to “Rushed”
- D remove the comma after “train”

Worked Example 16.1: Solution

Answer: B — rewrite as “Rushing to catch the train, she left the bags behind at the platform.”

PROCESS

1. Ask: who is “rushing to catch the train”?
2. The noun after the comma is “the bags” — bags cannot rush.
3. The person who rushed is not even in the sentence: a dangling modifier.
4. Rewrite so a person follows the comma: “..., she left the bags behind...”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The bags are doing the rushing.
- B** ✓ **A person now follows the comma.**
- C** ✗ Still describes the bags.
- D** ✗ Without the comma, the problem remains.

TIP

- Intro phrase? The NEXT word after the comma must be who or what does it.
- Ask: “Can this noun actually do this action?”

TRAP

- Changing the form of the phrase (“Rushed”) without fixing the subject.
- Removing the comma does not change who is rushing.



Worked Example 16.2

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The professor gave a lecture on ancient Rome in the main auditorium that lasted two hours.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B move “that lasted two hours” to directly follow “lecture”
- C change “lasted” to “lasting”
- D change “gave” to “gives”

Worked Example 16.2: Solution

Answer: B — move “that lasted two hours” to directly follow “lecture”

PROCESS

1. Ask what “that lasted two hours” describes: the LECTURE.
2. As written, it sits right after “auditorium”.
3. That makes it sound like the auditorium lasted two hours: a misplaced modifier.
4. Move it next to “lecture”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The modifier sits next to “auditorium”.
- B** ✓ **The modifier now sits next to “lecture”.**
- C** ✗ The position problem stays.
- D** ✗ A tense shift; the position problem stays.

TIP

- Modifiers hug the word they describe.
- A “that” or “which” phrase modifies the noun right before it.

TRAP

- Fixing the verb instead of the position.
- “As written” reads fine in casual speech.

Worked Example 16.3



CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Employees who complete the training thoroughly understand the new safety procedures. (Intended meaning: the training must be completed thoroughly.)

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B move “thoroughly” to before “complete”
- C change “thoroughly” to “thorough”
- D remove “thoroughly”

Worked Example 16.3: Solution

Answer: B — move “thoroughly” to before “complete”

PROCESS

1. Spot the middle word: “thoroughly” sits between two verb phrases.
2. It could describe “complete” OR “understand” — a squinting modifier.
3. The intended meaning: complete the training thoroughly.
4. Move it right next to “complete”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The placement is ambiguous.
- B** ✓ **“thoroughly complete the training” — clear.**
- C** ✗ An adjective cannot describe how they complete it.
- D** ✗ Removes the intended meaning.

TIP

- A modifier between two ideas can “squint” both ways.
- Put it directly beside the one word it describes.

TRAP

- Deleting the word loses the intended meaning.
- “thorough” is an adjective — it cannot describe a verb.



Worked Example 16.4

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

Covered in dust, Maria found the old photographs in the attic.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B rewrite as “Maria found the old photographs covered in dust in the attic.”
- C remove the comma after “dust”
- D rewrite as “Maria found the old photographs in the attic, covered in dust.”

Worked Example 16.4: Solution

Answer: B — rewrite as “Maria found the old photographs covered in dust in the attic.”

PROCESS

1. Ask: what is “covered in dust”?
2. Next to the phrase is “Maria” — but the photographs were dusty, not Maria.
3. The modifier is misplaced.
4. Move it right next to “the old photographs”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The phrase describes Maria.
- B** ✓ **The phrase sits next to “photographs”.**
- C** ✗ The phrase still attaches to Maria.
- D** ✗ The phrase now follows “attic” — still ambiguous.

TIP

- Ask “what exactly is covered in dust?” then glue the phrase to that noun.
- An intro phrase describes the noun right after the comma.

TRAP

- Keeping the intro phrase because it sounds natural.
- D moves the phrase beside “attic” — it could now describe the attic or Maria.

17

Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

Matching forms, matching pairs, matching things.

Παράλληλη Δομή

THEORY
9 slides

WORKED EXAMPLES
6 questions

The big idea

WHAT IT IS

When a sentence lists, pairs or compares things, every item must use the **SAME** grammatical form — and comparisons must compare the same **TYPE** of thing. This section covers parallel structure, the three kinds of conjunctions, and comparisons.

EXAMPLE

She likes swimming, running, and cycling.

KEY TERM • ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΑ

Παράλληλη Δομή

Όταν παραθέτουμε ή συγκρίνουμε στοιχεία σε μια πρόταση, πρέπει να έχουν την ίδια γραμματική μορφή.

WHY IT MATTERS

- The first item in a list sets the pattern
- Paired words (both...and, neither...nor) need matching halves
- In a comparison, compare like with like

What parallel means

RULE

EXAMPLE

WHY

Every item in a list uses the **SAME form**

She likes swimming, running, and cycling.

All three are -ing nouns.

Verbs match verbs: all base, all -ing, or all infinitives

to plan, to execute, and to review

A reader expects the pattern to continue.

Verb tense stays the same in a series

He cleaned the house, organized his files, and paid the bills.

All three are simple past.

Three kinds of connecting words

KIND	EXAMPLE	RULE
Coordinating (FANBOYS): for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	<i>The room was small but comfortable.</i>	Joins two EQUAL elements — same form on both sides.
Correlative pairs: both...and • either...or • neither...nor • not only...but also • whether...or	<i>The film was not only entertaining but also thought-provoking.</i>	The SAME structure after each half.
Subordinating: because, although, since, while, if, when, unless	<i>Although the team lost, they played well.</i>	Starts a dependent clause — never joined like a list item.

Compare like with like



RULE	EXAMPLE	WHY
Compare the same TYPE of thing	<i>The climate in Athens is milder than that of Moscow.</i>	Climate vs. climate — “that of” replaces the repeated noun.
That of / those of: match singular and plural	<i>The GDP of France is higher than THAT OF Germany.</i>	Singular “GDP” → “that of”.

Three parallel errors

RULE	WRONG EXAMPLE	WHY
Mixed forms in a list	✗ <i>She likes swimming, running, and to cycle.</i>	The third item switches to to + verb.
Different forms after a correlative pair	✗ <i>She was both talented and she worked hard.</i>	Adjective after “both”, full clause after “and”.
Comparing unlike things	✗ <i>The climate in Athens is milder than Moscow.</i>	A climate cannot be compared to a city.

Spot the parallel error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ The job requires patience, creativity, and being organized.

✗ Either call me or sending an email.

✗ The plan was neither well organized nor was it funded.

✗ Her scores are higher than her brother.

RIGHT

✓ The job requires patience, creativity, and organization.

✓ Either call me or send an email.

✓ The plan was neither well organized nor properly funded.

✓ Her scores are higher than her brother's.

WHY

Nouns, nouns, noun.

Same verb form after each half.

Match the shape after “nor”.

Scores vs. scores — not scores vs. a person.

“Like” and “as”: look at what follows

WORD

EXAMPLE

HOW TO CHOOSE

LIKE + a noun or pronoun (NO verb after it)

Like her mentor, she excelled.

“Like” means “similar to”. It compares two nouns.

AS + a clause (a subject AND a verb follow)

She performed as her mentor had predicted.

“As” means “in the way that”. A verb comes after it.

AS + a noun for a role or job

She worked as a nurse.

“As” means “in the role of”.

The one-second test

Is there a verb after the blank?

Yes → AS. No → LIKE.

Spot the like / as error — and fix it

WRONG

✗ He plays chess like his father does.

✗ She sings as her sister.

✗ Like the report predicted, sales rose.

✗ He spoke like the host of the event.

RIGHT

✓ He plays chess as his father does.

✓ She sings like her sister.

✓ As the report predicted, sales rose.

✓ He spoke as the host of the event.

WHY

A verb follows (“does”) → as.

No verb follows → like.

“Predicted” is a verb → as.

His role was host → as.

Parallel structure in three lines

Lists

- Check the FIRST item's form
- Match every other item to it

Pairs

- Underline what follows each half
- Same grammatical shape on both sides
- Both/and • either/or • neither/nor • not only/but also

Comparisons

- Ask: same TYPE of thing?
- Use that of / those of
- Fewer = countable • less = uncountable



17

Worked Example 17.1

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The new manager was praised for being both efficient and she showed great creativity.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change to “both efficient and creative”
- C change to “both being efficient and creative”
- D change to “both efficiency and creativity”

17

Worked Example 17.1: Solution

Answer: B — change to “both efficient and creative”

PROCESS

1. Find the pair: both ... and.
2. After “both”: the adjective “efficient”.
3. After “and” there must be the same form — an adjective: “creative”.
4. “both efficient and creative” — adjective + adjective.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Adjective vs. full clause: not parallel.
- B** ✓ **Adjective + adjective.**
- C** ✗ Repeats “being”: “for being both being...”.
- D** ✗ “being ... efficiency” — a person is not a noun like “efficiency”.

TIP

- Underline what follows each half of the pair; the two must match.
- Both/and, either/or, neither/nor, not only/but also all need parallel halves.

TRAP

- Leaving the full clause “she showed great creativity” after “and”.
- C and D keep matching “shapes” but clash with “for being”.



17

Worked Example 17.2

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The design was neither cost-effective nor did it look particularly appealing.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change to “neither cost-effective nor particularly appealing”
- C change to “neither cost-effective nor it looked appealing”
- D change “neither” to “either”

17

Worked Example 17.2: Solution

Answer: B — change to “neither cost-effective nor particularly appealing”

PROCESS

1. Find the pair: neither ... nor.
2. After “neither”: the adjective “cost-effective”.
3. After “nor”: a full clause “did it look particularly appealing” — mismatch.
4. Make it match: “nor particularly appealing”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Adjective vs. clause.
- B** ✓ **Adjective phrase + adjective phrase.**
- C** ✗ Still a full clause after “nor”.
- D** ✗ “either ... nor” is not a pair.

TIP

- Match the shape after each half: adjective + adjective, noun + noun, verb + verb.
- Delete the extra subject and verb after “nor”.

TRAP

- Fixing the tense (C) but leaving a clause after “nor”.
- Changing neither → either: “either ... nor” is not a pair.



17

Worked Example 17.3

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The average commute time in the capital is longer than most other cities in the country.

Which choice is best?

- A** is correct as written
- B** change to “longer than that of most other cities”
- C** change to “longer than those of most other cities”
- D** change “longer” to “more long”

17

Worked Example 17.3: Solution

Answer: B — change to “longer than that of most other cities”

PROCESS

1. Ask what is being compared: commute TIME vs. “most other cities”.
2. A time cannot be compared to a city.
3. Add “that of” so the second item is also a commute time.
4. “...longer than that of most other cities” — time vs. time.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Compares a time to cities.
- B** ✓ **“That of” = the commute time of other cities.**
- C** ✗ “Those” is plural; “time” is singular.
- D** ✗ “more long” is not standard English.

TIP

- In a comparison, both sides must be the same kind of thing.
- Use “that of” (singular) or “those of” (plural) to replace the repeated noun.

TRAP

- “those of” — a plural pronoun for singular “commute time”.
- “more long” — wrong form; “longer” is already correct.



17

Worked Example 17.4

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

To succeed in this role, candidates must communicate clearly, work independently, and showing initiative.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “showing” to “show”
- C change “work” to “working”
- D change “communicate” to “communicating”

17

Worked Example 17.4: Solution

Answer: B — change “showing” to “show”

PROCESS

1. Find the list: communicate, work, and showing.
2. The first two are base verbs (after “must”).
3. The third item must match: “show”.
4. “...communicate clearly, work independently, and show initiative.”

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ The last item breaks the pattern.
- B** ✓ **The base form matches the first two.**
- C** ✗ Changes a correct item and breaks the pattern.
- D** ✗ Changes a correct item and breaks the pattern.

TIP

- Check the **FIRST** item of a list, then match every other item to it.
- After “must / can / will”, use base verbs.

TRAP

- Changing the first two verbs instead of the odd one out.
- -ing forms sound smooth but break the pattern.



17

Worked Example 17.5

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

She had to decide whether to accept the promotion or she could stay in her current position.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change to “whether to accept the promotion or to stay in her current position”
- C change to “whether accepting the promotion or to stay in her current position”
- D remove “or”

17

Worked Example 17.5: Solution

Answer: B — change to “whether to accept the promotion or to stay in her current position”

PROCESS

1. Find the pair: whether ... or.
2. After “whether”: “to accept the promotion” (an infinitive phrase).
3. After “or”: a full clause “she could stay...” — mismatch.
4. Match the form: “or to stay in her current position”.

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ Infinitive phrase vs. full clause.
- B** ✓ **Infinitive + infinitive.**
- C** ✗ “accepting ... to stay” mixes forms.
- D** ✗ “whether ... she could stay” loses the pair and the sense.

TIP

- Whether ... or needs the same form after each half — often to + verb.
- Cut any extra subject and helper verb after “or”.

TRAP

- Choosing C: it mixes -ing and to + verb.
- Removing “or” destroys the pair.



17

Worked Example 17.6

CLC PRACTICE QUESTION

The new teacher explains grammar like the previous teacher did.

Which choice is best?

- A is correct as written
- B change “like” to “as”
- C change “like” to “such as”
- D change “did” to “does”

17

Worked Example 17.6: Solution

Answer: B — change “like” to “as”

PROCESS

1. Look at what follows “like”: “the previous teacher did”.
2. That is a clause: subject “teacher” + verb “did”.
3. A clause after the word needs “as” (in the way that).
4. “...explains grammar as the previous teacher did.”

PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

- A** ✗ “Like” cannot introduce a clause with its own verb.
- B** ✓ **“As” introduces the clause “the previous teacher did”.**
- C** ✗ “Such as” gives examples; it does not compare.
- D** ✗ Changing the tense does not fix the connecting word.

TIP

- Verb after the blank? → AS. No verb? → LIKE.
- “Like” compares nouns; “as” compares actions.

TRAP

- “Like” sounds natural in everyday speech.
- “Such as” introduces examples, not comparisons.



Choose the punctuation

IF YOU SEE...	USE...	EXAMPLE
Two complete sentences, no connector	Period or semicolon	<i>The rain stopped; everyone went outside.</i>
Two complete sentences + FANBOYS	Comma BEFORE the FANBOYS word	<i>It rained, so we stayed in.</i>
Two complete sentences + however / therefore	; however,	<i>The test was hard; however, most passed.</i>
A complete sentence, then a list or explanation	Colon	<i>She had one goal: to win.</i>
Extra information in the middle	A matched pair: , ... , or — ... —	<i>My car, which is old, still runs.</i>
Dependent clause before the main clause	Comma after the dependent clause	<i>Although it rained, we played.</i>
Preposition + object, or subject + verb	NO punctuation between them	<i>pages from a collection of tales</i>



Grammar checks in one glance

Agreement & verbs

- Cross out phrases between subject and verb
- AND → plural · OR / NOR → closer subject
- A number of → plural · The number of → singular
- There is / are: subject comes AFTER the verb
- Match the anchor tense unless time changes

Pronouns & apostrophes

- Find the antecedent first
- its = belongs · it's = it is
- who = he / she · whom = him / her
- One owner: 's · several owners: s'
- Fewer = countable · less = uncountable

Modifiers & structure

- Intro phrase: the noun after the comma must do it
- Keep a modifier next to what it describes
- Lists: match the FIRST item
- Pairs: same shape after each half
- Comparisons: like with like (that of / those of)

5

Five steps for every question

1

Read

Read the whole sentence — not just the blank.

2

Spot

Look at HOW the answer choices differ.

3

Name

Name the rule that difference is testing.

4

Apply

Apply the rule. Ignore how it 'sounds'.

5

Check

Eliminate the wrong choices, then re-read your answer.